

Session 1: Understanding Ezekiel

Key Takeaways

- The composer of Ezekiel coordinates the book within the larger story of the Hebrew Bible by linking the opening lines of the scroll to the events in 2 Kings.
- Ezekiel is a war refugee and captive who has been stripped of all social standing and exiled in a foreign land.
- Ezekiel lives in the window between two tragedies. His job is to tell his fellow exiles about the greater tragedy on the horizon.

Starting Point #1: Who Is Ezekiel?

The book of Ezekiel begins with a narrative about an Israelite sitting by a river (or, more likely, an irrigation canal) in Babylon. This man is the son of a priest, and he lives among a group of exiled Israelites.

Ezekiel 1:1-4 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now it came about in the thirtieth year,
on the fifth day of the fourth month,
while I was among the exiles,
by the river Chebar among the exiles,
the skies were opened
and I saw visions of *Elohim*.

² “On the fifth of the month”—This is the fifth year of the exile of King Jehoiachin.

³ The word of Yahweh came to Ezekiel, son of Buzi, the priest,
in the land of the Chaldeans,
by the river Chebar,
and there the hand of Yahweh came upon him.

⁴ ... and I saw, and look: a storm wind was coming from the north ...

Who is this man? Where is he exactly? Why and how did he get there? The explanatory notes in 1:2-3 serve as hyperlinks to the story of Judah's kings and Jehoiachin in particular, which is found in the scroll of [2 Kings 24-25](#).

The king of Babylon first attacked the city of Jerusalem in the year 597 (see [2 Kgs. 24:10-16](#)), when he took the current king from the line of David away into captivity along with the leaders of the city (including Ezekiel, Daniel, and lots of others).

Babylon appointed new puppet leaders, including a new king, Zedekiah, who ruled in Jerusalem for 9.5 years, until he joined a rebel alliance with Egypt against Babylon (see [Ezek. 17:15](#)).

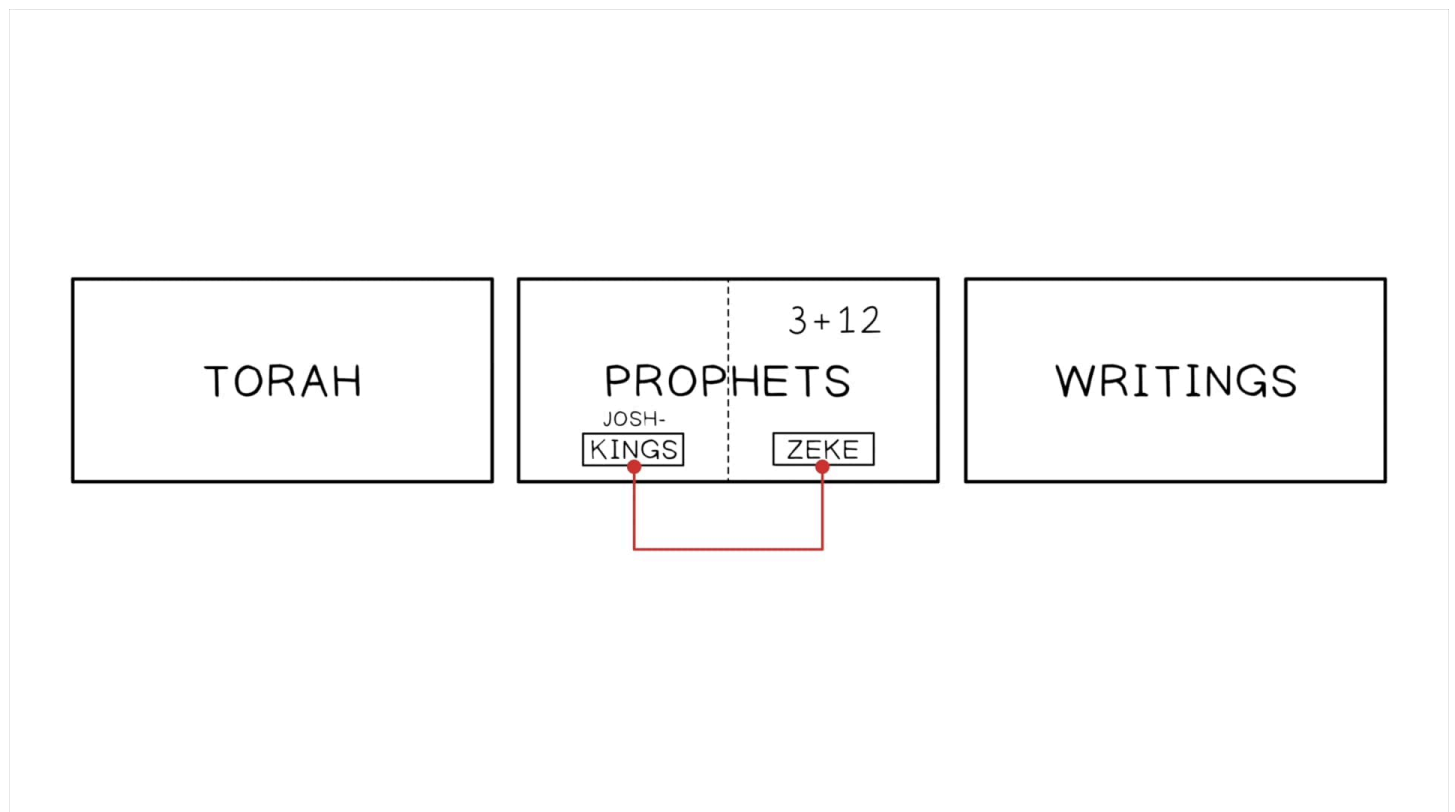
Babylon came back with a vengeance and besieged Jerusalem for 1.5 years until the city collapsed from food and water shortages (see 2 Kgs. 25).

So Ezekiel is a war refugee and a political prisoner who was taken from his homeland and forced to live in a refugee camp in the flood plains of Babylon. And there Ezekiel has a frightening encounter with the God of Israel who commissions him to give a message to his people.

But this is only the first level of explanation, and it raises some bigger questions.

- Where am I in the larger plotline of the biblical story?
- How does this character (Ezekiel, a prophet-priest) and how do these places (Jerusalem and Babylon) fit into the larger themes of that story?
- Why does any of this matter?

TaNaK Prophets Links



TaNaK Prophets Links. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How does knowing Ezekiel's personal experience as a war refugee, captive, and exiled priest shape the way we read his scroll?